

The Witch's Prophecy

"Apostle Helena, are you ready to share your prophecy?" The elderly woman, sitting across from Helena at the fire, carried a weight upon her shoulders—the burden of leading their Order, mixed with the pride of seeing those she'd raised reach such an important milestone.

"Yes, Mother Megania. I have long looked forward to becoming a sister of the Order of the Eye. I fear that the Order is not ready for my prophecy, though." Megania, along with the other sisters beside her, raised an eyebrow at this. It was a rite of passage for all witches in the Order to develop a prophecy—a sign of their maturity, their awareness of the world and insight into the future. Most prophecies were simple; for some, it was as basic as claiming that someone's marriage would fall apart, or that a major power would soon make a move that would change the balance of power. Few witches in the past had been bold enough to proclaim a prophecy of such magnitude that it would warrant discretion, though.

Megania sighed to herself for a moment. Helena had always been different. From an early age, she had been chosen by the Eye, granted a sliver of its unending power—a seed she had nurtured in herself for years. Once she had reached the age where she could make her prophecy, she put it on hold; she spent several years developing her prophecy, always hinting that she didn't have enough yet, that she wasn't ready. Truth be told, she was one of the most powerful in the order by now; she was a sister in every way but officially. Helena cleared her throat and looked around at her fellow members.

"Long have we considered ourselves the most enlightened group in the galaxy. We have seen the Eye, know its existence for ourselves. Our search for knowledge has been unending; our eyes will not be covered. If there is a truth in existence, be it among the stars or around us, we will find it. It is this tradition that gives me hope that you will hear my words and choose not to shield yourselves from what will come to pass. My sisters, I have been among the stars; I have seen the coming void for myself. The Weave-Eaters are real. I know what the future holds.

"And thus, I declare: one day—and I know not when—there will be a cataclysm. Reality as we know it will be shaken, and magic, the foundation of much of our lives, will be lost. My sisters, one day, the Eye will be no more."

Megania's eyes widened; the other sisters immediately began whispering amongst themselves aggressively. What Helena had just asserted was heresy of the highest magnitude. The Eye was *everything*. Without its power, there could be no life, no planets, no magic. The Eye's benevolence is the reason for their existence. Its worship was a key pillar of life within the Order. If Helena, who'd been here since birth and was such a revered member, was sure of this, then she surely must have a reason for believing it.

"Helena, we must discuss your prophecy—*without* you. Leave our presence; we will call for you once we have reached a conclusion," Megania said. She knew that Helena would immediately recognize this as an unusual step; typically, the Mother immediately accepted a prophecy or told the apostle that they needed to develop it further. There would also have been time for the apostle

to defend their prophecy—Helena’s prophecy was given no opportunity to present this, and it would not get that.

As Helena left, the whispers grew into an outright fervor; sisters were talking over each other, determined to have their input heard by the mother. There was at least one call to execute Helena for her heresy; while this would normally be the treatment for heresy of such magnitude, though, Megania knew this would be a bad decision. Helena’s words had weight; if she said something, it was likely to be true. If word got out about her prophecy, it would inspire others to look into her words, to search for what drove her to such an extreme. No, the best solution would be exile. It would give them a plausible excuse, should anyone uncover her prophecy in the future. The sisters and Megania could claim that Helena’s prophecy was riddled with incorrect assertions, and it was clear that her values had split from those held by the Order. She would be sent away but kept alive for now as thanks for her many years of contributions to the Order. Then, perhaps later, if she insisted on spreading this information, there were steps that could be taken...

Megania explained her decision to the other sisters; they weren’t happy with it, but they reluctantly agreed. The Mother commanded total respect from all within the Order; the sisters that were allowed to hear the prophecies carried influence, but they knew better than to go against the Mother. Megania summoned Helena back into the room.

“Helena, what you have declared tonight is heresy of the highest order. However, we have decided to spare your life. You will pack up your belongings tonight, and you will leave in the morning on the ship out to Bral. You are exiled from this place, never to return; you will say nothing of your prophecy to anyone. We will honor your years of service by proclaiming your exile is simply the result of your values no longer matching with ours. Should you do anything to compromise this, you will be executed. Have we made ourselves clear?” Helena looked shocked; she started to say something but paused for a moment and thought.

“I understand, Mother. Thank you for your grace, and for giving me a home for so long.” With that, Helena bowed, turned around, and left. Come tomorrow, this experience would be past them all, and they could begin to move on.